Bandit 2

A drop-in adventure in three acts for characters of level 3

D&D 5e (2024)

Contents

Act 1: The Caravan **5**
- Guarding the Caravan 6
- Attack 1: Outside Millbrook 20
- Attack 2: The Midway Ambush 25
- Attack 3: Before Harrowgate 30
- Road Encounters 36

Act 2: The Trail **46**
- Following the Trail 47
- The Bear 58
- The Crow Camp 60
- The Lookout Post 68

Act 3: The Bandit Lord **69**
- The Bandit Lord's Lair 70
- The Lair Gate 71
- The Bandit Lord 72

Key NPCs **73**

Key locations **75**

Bandit 2

A short, standalone adventure for four or five characters of level 3, in three acts of about one session each. It drops into any campaign as part of the main plot or as a side quest, and scales to other levels.

Goal

Protect a merchant caravan from bandits, track the bandits back to their hideout, and end the bandit lord's hold on the trade road.

Overview

A bandit lord who calls himself **the Rook** has taken over Ashwatch, an abandoned toll fort deep in the Ashwood, the forest the Old Trade Road passes through. He wants to be the only boss in the region, and in his own mind he is already its king. From it, his gang, the Crows, demand a "toll" from every traveler, and they rob any caravan that refuses to pay. Trade between the two towns at either end of the road is drying up.

Central arc

1. **Act 1: The Caravan.** A caravan master in the starting town hires the party to guard a caravan on its three-day journey along the road. The Crows attack, and the party drives them off. A bandit taken alive, a dropped token, or the tracks the raiders leave point back toward their hideout.
2. **Act 2: The Trail.** In Harrowgate, the driver's cousin and the captain of the guard ask the party to find out why the attacks have grown. A captured Crow, if the party can make him talk, leads them to the camp of Brannoc, a Crow lieutenant in the woods. By questioning Brannoc or finding his hidden stash of documents, the party learns that the Rook sees himself as a king and where his fort is, and sets out for it.
3. **Act 3: The Bandit Lord.** The party reaches Ashwatch, the old fort in the woods. They can sneak in, bargain, or fight their way through, and in the end they confront the Rook.

The main arc is open: the party can choose how to find the hideout, whether to fight or talk, and what to do with the Rook and his gang.

Using this adventure

- **Setting.** Places and people have plain placeholder names (Millbrook, Harrowgate, the Old Trade Road, the Ashwood). Rename them to fit your world.

- **Hooks.** The party may be traveling the road already, may need money, or may be sent by a patron from your campaign. To tie the adventure into your main plot, let the Rook hold something the party needs, such as a stolen item, a letter, or a captive, or have him take orders from one of your campaign's villains.
- **Scaling.** Encounters are built for four characters of level 3. Each encounter has notes for weaker or stronger parties.

Rules

D&D 5e (2024). Stat blocks come from the open-licensed System Reference Document for this edition, or are original.

This work includes material from the System Reference Document 5.2 ("SRD 5.2") by Wizards of the Coast LLC, available at https://www.dndbeyond.com/srd. The SRD 5.2 is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License, available at https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/legalcode.

Chapters

1. Act 1: The Caravan
2. Act 2: The Trail
3. Act 3: The Bandit Lord

Indexes

- Key NPCs
- Key items
- Key locations

Act 1: The Caravan

Session 1. Level 3.

In a Millbrook tavern, coach driver Tobin Marsh hires the party to guard his three-wagon caravan on its three-day journey along the Old Trade Road to Harrowgate. His cousin Hester runs Marsh Freight there. Marsh Freight refused to pay the Rook's toll, so the Crows attack three times: just outside Millbrook, at Crow's Ford halfway along the road, and on the last hill before Harrowgate. Tobin is killed in the second attack, and the party must bring the caravan and the news to Hester.

Place in the story

- **Comes from:** The adventure hook (see campaign.md).
- **Leads to:** Act 2: The Trail, which begins as the caravan reaches Harrowgate. Note what the party did with Tobin's body; it decides Hester's reaction. The party brings leads from the attacks: crow-feather tokens, Sable's toll ledger, the raiders' tracks, or a captured Crow.

Adventures

1. Guarding the Caravan

Encounters

1. Attack 1: Outside Millbrook: Low, 450 XP
2. Attack 2: The Midway Ambush: Moderate, 950 XP. Tobin dies.
3. Attack 3: Before Harrowgate: Low to Moderate, 500–950 XP
4. Road Encounters: optional random encounter table

Guarding the Caravan

Act 1. One session. Four or five characters of level 3.

A coach driver hires the party in a Millbrook tavern to guard his caravan on the three-day journey to Harrowgate. The Crows, the gang of a warlord called the Rook, attack three times along the way. In the second attack, the driver is killed. The party must bring the caravan, and the news, to his cousin in Harrowgate.

Background

The Rook is a greedy warlord who wants to be the only boss in the region, with every gang, merchant, and coin answering to him. He sees himself as a king. From Ashwatch, an old toll fort deep in the Ashwood, his gang, the Crows, have taken over the Old Trade Road between Millbrook and Harrowgate. They make every traveler pay "the Rook's toll": one wagon in three, or fifty gold a wagon.

Marsh Freight, a small caravan company based in Harrowgate, refused to pay. The Rook has decided to make an example of them. Its owner, **Hester Marsh**, has sent her cousin **Tobin** to bring a caravan back from Millbrook. Tobin knows the Crows will come for him, so he is looking for guards.

Cast

Name	Who they are	At the table
Tobin Marsh	Coach driver for Marsh Freight; Hester's cousin. Fifties, weathered, stubborn, kind.	Hums old road songs, calls the horses "my ladies", won't bow to bullies. Dies at the midway ford.
Petra	Teamster on the second wagon. Young, sharp-tongued, brave.	Carries the signal horn. Takes over as lead driver after Tobin dies.
Wil	Teamster on the third wagon. Older, nervous, devout.	Wants to turn back after the ford.
Hester Marsh	Head of Marsh Freight in Harrowgate. Tobin's cousin.	Waits in Harrowgate. Grieving and furious when she hears the news. Leads into Act 2.
Gully	Crow, tough. Cheerful, loud, not very bright.	Demands the toll in Attack 1.
Sable	Crow lieutenant, the Rook's right hand. Cold, precise.	Leads the midway ambush, and Attack 3 if she escapes.
The Rook	Warlord, leader of the Crows.	Never seen in Act 1. His name, his toll, and his crow-feather tokens are everywhere.

1. The tavern in Millbrook

The party is at the **Plough and Lantern**, a busy tavern by Millbrook's east gate where teamsters and travelers drink before taking the road.

> *A broad-shouldered man in a dusty driving coat pushes through the crowd to your table, hat in hand. "Tobin Marsh, Marsh Freight. You look like folk who can handle yourselves. I've got three wagons leaving for Harrowgate at first light, and I need guards. There's bandits on the road, and they've got a grudge against my company."*

What Tobin offers: 10 gp each now and 40 gp each when the caravan reaches Harrowgate, paid by his cousin Hester, who runs the company. Meals on the road are included. A character who succeeds on a DC 13 Charisma (Persuasion) check raises the payment on arrival to 50 gp each. Tobin isn't a rich man, but he knows he needs help.

What Tobin tells them:

- The bandits call themselves the Crows. They work for someone called "the Rook" and demand a toll from anyone on the road.
- Marsh Freight refused to pay. "It's our road too. My grandfather drove it before any Rook was hatched."
- The wagons carry wool cloth, salt, and iron tools: honest goods Harrowgate needs.
- The journey takes three days: farmland, then the Ashwood, then the hills above Harrowgate.
- His cousin Hester runs the company. "She's the clever one. I'm just the one who drives."

If the party turns him down, Tobin leaves the caravan that morning anyway. A day later, the party hears the Crows burned his wagons on the road. If you need to bring them back in, Hester's letter arrives asking them to find her cousin's killers (start Act 2 directly).

2. The road

The journey takes three days. Use this timeline, adding road encounters where you want them (no more than one a day for a level 3 party).

When	Where	What happens
Day 1, morning	Hills just outside Millbrook	Attack 1: Outside Millbrook. Gully demands the toll.
Day 1, afternoon and night	Farmland, roadside camp	Travel scene: Tobin's stories. Roll for a road encounter.
Day 2, midday	Crow's Ford in the Ashwood	Attack 2: The Midway Ambush. **Tobin is killed.**

When	Where	What happens
Day 2, afternoon and night	Ashwood	Travel scene: what now? Roll for a road encounter.
Day 3, late afternoon	The last hill before Harrowgate	Attack 3: Before Harrowgate. The Crows try to burn the caravan.
Day 3, evening	Harrowgate	Arrival. Hester Marsh.

The party can take a Short Rest after each attack while the teamsters calm the horses and check the loads. They get a Long Rest each night unless a road encounter interrupts it.

Travel scene: Tobin's stories (day 1)

Give the players a reason to like Tobin before he dies. Around the fire, he:

- tells how his grandfather drove this road with a single mule, and how Hester turned the family's one wagon into a company of twelve;
- asks each character where they're from and what they'll do with their pay;
- shows a small carved wooden horse he's bringing home for Hester's daughter;
- admits, quietly, that he's afraid, "but I'd be more afraid of a world where you pay a man like the Rook to use your own road."

Travel scene: what now? (day 2, after the ford)

After Tobin's death, the teamsters are shaken.

- **Wil** wants to turn back to Millbrook. Petra wants to go on: "Tobin would've gone on." The party decides. Going back means a day and a half on the road the Crows know well, and so does going on.
- **Petra** takes Tobin's place at the reins.
- **Tobin's body.** Let the party decide what to do with it, without saying that it matters. They can wrap it and carry it on a wagon to Harrowgate, bury it by the road, or leave it. Petra and Wil follow the party's lead. Note what the party chooses: **Hester's reaction and the party's bonus in Act 2 depend on it** (see Hester's reaction).
- **The wooden horse** is in Tobin's coat pocket.
- A character who comforts the teamsters (a DC 12 Charisma (Persuasion) check or a good bit of roleplay) steadies them. If nobody does, Wil slips away in the night and walks back to Millbrook, and the third wagon needs a new driver.

3. The three attacks

Each attack is written out in full in its encounter file, and the stat blocks are also in the appendix at the end of this file.

Attack 1: Outside Millbrook

Full encounter. *Low (450 XP).*

Less than an hour out of town, an overturned handcart blocks the road. Gully (a tough) and six bandits demand the toll while two scouts hide on the hillside above (DC 16 to spot). Tobin refuses. The Crows fight from behind the cart and scatter when Gully drops or half of them are down. This is a test of the guards' strength. **Leads:** a captured bandit names the Rook and Sable; every Crow wears a crow-feather token stamped with a tower.

Attack 2: The Midway Ambush

Full encounter. *Moderate (950 XP).*

At Crow's Ford in the Ashwood, the wagons are stuck in knee-deep water when Sable (a bandit captain), two toughs, four bandits, and two scouts in the trees open fire. **Tobin is killed in the opening volley**; this is scripted, not rolled. If the party reaches him, he lives just long enough to say: "*Tell Hester... I wouldn't pay. Tell her it was Sable. The tower on the feathers. Don't let him win.*" Sable flees on horseback when Bloodied. **Leads:** Sable's toll ledger, with a sketch of the hill trail on the back page.

Attack 3: Before Harrowgate

Full encounter. *Low to Moderate (500 XP, or 950 XP with Sable).*

In a sunken lane on the last hill, with Harrowgate's walls in sight, the Crows block the road with a burning hay cart and throw torches at the wagons. A wagon on fire for three rounds is lost. Petra's signal horn brings the Harrowgate watch in round 5. If Sable escaped the ford, she leads this attack. **Leads:** the Crows' tracks lead northeast into the hills; a captured Crow knows about the lookout post.

4. On to Harrowgate

Act 1 ends when the caravan rolls through Harrowgate's west gate on the evening of day 3. Meeting Hester Marsh, the party's pay, and the bonus for how they treated Tobin's body are all at the start of Act 2: Following the Trail.

Before moving on, note:

- what the party did with **Tobin's body** (carried it to Harrowgate, buried it by the road, or left it);
- how many **wagons** survived;
- whether the party has the **wooden horse** and heard **Tobin's last words**;
- which **leads** the party has (below).

The leads so far

Whatever happened, the party should leave Act 1 with at least one of these. If they have none, Hester has one: a Crow who was caught by the Harrowgate watch and is in the town jail.

Lead	Where it comes from	Where it points
Crow-feather tokens stamped with a squat tower	Every Crow	The old toll fort in the woods (the tower is Ashwatch's mark)
Sable's toll ledger, with a trail sketch	Sable's saddlebag (Attack 2)	A trail into the Ashwood, north of the road
Tracks heading north	Attack 3 site	Brannoc's Crow camp at the eastern edge of the Ashwood
A captured Crow	Any attack	A Crow camp in the woods near Harrowgate (see Act 2)
Oda the peddler's story	Road encounter 8	Lantern flashes in the treetops deep in the Ashwood

Rewards

- **Pay:** 10 gp each up front, and 40 gp (or 50 gp) each when Hester pays them at the start of Act 2, plus a bonus depending on what they did with Tobin's body.
- **Loot:** Each Crow carries 1d6 sp and a crow-feather token. Gully carries 12 gp. Sable carries 25 gp and the toll ledger.
- **Experience:** If you use milestones, the party should be close to level 4 by the end of Act 2. For XP, the three attacks are worth 1,900–2,350 XP in total for the whole party.

Appendix: Stat blocks

All the creatures in Act 1: first the Crows, then the creatures from the road encounters. Gully uses the Tough stat block (or the Tough Boss for a stronger party). The animal and goblin stat blocks are for the optional road encounters.

Sable (Bandit Captain)

Sable is built from the SRD 5.2 Bandit Captain. **Change:** her Pistol is replaced with a Hand Crossbow, so she fits settings without firearms. If your setting has firearms, give her back the Pistol (*Ranged Attack Roll:* +5, range 30/90 ft. *Hit:* 8 (1d10 + 3) Piercing damage).

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 15 · **Initiative** +3 (13)

- **HP** 52 (8d8 + 16)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +4, Dex +5, Con +2, Int +2, Wis +2, Cha +2
- **Skills** Athletics +4, Deception +4
- **Gear** Hand Crossbow, Scimitar, Studded Leather Armor
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 2 (XP 450; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** Sable makes two attacks, using Scimitar and Hand Crossbow in any combination.
- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) Slashing damage.
- ***Hand Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +5, range 30/120 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) Piercing damage.

Reactions

- ***Parry.*** *Trigger:* Sable is hit by a melee attack roll while holding a weapon. *Response:* Sable adds 2 to her AC against that attack, possibly causing it to miss.

Tough

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 32 (5d8 + 10)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +2, Dex +1, Con +2, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Heavy Crossbow, Leather Armor, Mace
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The tough has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the tough's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Mace.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Bludgeoning damage.
- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d10 + 1) Piercing damage.

Bandit

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +1, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Light Crossbow, Scimitar
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 1/8 (XP 25; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +3, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) Slashing damage.
- ***Light Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 80/320 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) Piercing damage.

Scout

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 13 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 16 (3d8 + 3)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +2, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +1, Cha +0
- **Skills** Nature +4, Perception +5, Stealth +6, Survival +5
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Longbow, Shortsword
- **Senses** Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The scout makes two attacks, using Shortsword and Longbow in any combination.
- ***Shortsword.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage.
- ***Longbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 150/600 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) Piercing damage.

Tough Boss

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 16 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 82 (11d8 + 33)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
17 (+3)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +5, Dex +2, Con +5, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +2
- **Gear** Chain Mail, Heavy Crossbow, Warhammer
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 4 (XP 1,100; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The tough has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the tough's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The tough makes two attacks, using Warhammer or Heavy Crossbow in any combination.

- ***Warhammer.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 12 (2d8 + 3) Bludgeoning damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, the tough pushes the target up to 10 feet straight away from itself.
- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 13 (2d10 + 2) Piercing damage.

Wolf

Medium Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 40 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
14 (+2)	15 (+2)	12 (+1)	3 (−4)	12 (+1)	6 (−2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +2, Dex +2, Con +1, Int −4, Wis +1, Cha −2
- **Skills** Perception +5, Stealth +4
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1/4 (XP 50; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The wolf has Advantage on attack rolls against a creature if at least one of the wolf's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Bite.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage. If the target is a Medium or smaller creature, it has the Prone condition.

Dire Wolf

Large Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 14 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 22 (3d10 + 6)
- **Speed** 50 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
17 (+3)	15 (+2)	15 (+2)	3 (−4)	12 (+1)	7 (−2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +3, Dex +2, Con +2, Int −4, Wis +1, Cha −2
- **Skills** Perception +5, Stealth +4
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The wolf has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the wolf's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Bite.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 8 (1d10 + 3) Piercing damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, it has the Prone condition.

Boar

Medium Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 11 · **Initiative** +0 (10)
- **HP** 13 (2d8 + 4)
- **Speed** 40 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
13 (+1)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	2 (−4)	9 (−1)	5 (−3)

- **Saving Throws** Str +1, Dex +0, Con +2, Int −4, Wis −1, Cha −3
- **Senses** Passive Perception 9
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1/4 (XP 50; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Bloodied Fury.*** While Bloodied, the boar has Advantage on attack rolls.

Actions

- ***Gore.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +3, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) Piercing damage. If the target is a Medium or smaller creature and the boar moved 20+ feet straight toward it

immediately before the hit, the target takes an extra 3 (1d6) Piercing damage and has the Prone condition.

Brown Bear

Large Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 11 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 22 (3d10 + 6)
- **Speed** 40 ft., Climb 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
17 (+3)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	2 (−4)	13 (+1)	7 (−2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +3, Dex +1, Con +2, Int −4, Wis +1, Cha −2
- **Skills** Perception +3
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 13
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The bear makes one Bite attack and one Claw attack.
- ***Bite.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) Piercing damage.
- ***Claw.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) Slashing damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, it has the Prone condition.

Giant Spider

Large Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 14 · **Initiative** +3 (13)
- **HP** 26 (4d10 + 4)
- **Speed** 30 ft., Climb 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
14 (+2)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	2 (−4)	11 (+0)	4 (−3)

- **Saving Throws** Str +2, Dex +3, Con +1, Int −4, Wis +0, Cha −3
- **Skills** Perception +4, Stealth +7
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 14
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Spider Climb.*** The spider can climb difficult surfaces, including along ceilings, without needing to make an ability check.
- ***Web Walker.*** The spider ignores movement restrictions caused by webs, and it knows the location of any other creature in contact with the same web.

Actions

- ***Bite.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) Piercing damage plus 7 (2d6) Poison damage.
- ***Web (Recharge 5–6).*** *Dexterity Saving Throw:* DC 13, one creature the spider can see within 60 feet. *Failure:* The target has the Restrained condition until the web is destroyed (AC 10; HP 5; Vulnerability to Fire damage; Immunity to Poison and Psychic damage).

Goblin Warrior

Small Fey (Goblinoid), Chaotic Neutral

- **AC** 15 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 10 (3d6)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
8 (−1)	15 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	8 (−1)	8 (−1)

- **Saving Throws** Str −1, Dex +2, Con +0, Int +0, Wis −1, Cha −1
- **Skills** Stealth +6
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Scimitar, Shield, Shortbow
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 9
- **Languages** Common, Goblin
- **CR** 1/4 (XP 50; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Slashing damage, plus 2 (1d4) Slashing damage if the attack roll had Advantage.
- ***Shortbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 80/320 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage, plus 2 (1d4) Piercing damage if the attack roll had Advantage.

Bonus Actions

- ***Nimble Escape.*** The goblin takes the Disengage or Hide action.

Goblin Boss

Small Fey (Goblinoid), Chaotic Neutral

- **AC** 17 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 21 (6d6)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
10 (+0)	15 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	8 (−1)	10 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +2, Con +0, Int +0, Wis −1, Cha +0
- **Skills** Stealth +6
- **Gear** Chain Shirt, Scimitar, Shield, Shortbow
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 9
- **Languages** Common, Goblin
- **CR** 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The goblin makes two attacks, using Scimitar or Shortbow in any combination.
- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Slashing damage, plus 2 (1d4) Slashing damage if the attack roll had Advantage.
- ***Shortbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 80/320 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage, plus 2 (1d4) Piercing damage if the attack roll had Advantage.

Bonus Actions

- ***Nimble Escape.*** The goblin takes the Disengage or Hide action.

Reactions

- ***Redirect Attack.*** *Trigger:* A creature the goblin can see makes an attack roll against it. *Response:* The goblin chooses a Small or Medium ally within 5 feet of itself. The goblin and that ally swap places, and the ally becomes the target of the attack instead.

Swarm of Ravens

Medium Swarm of Tiny Beasts, Unaligned

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 10 ft., Fly 50 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
6 (−2)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	5 (−3)	12 (+1)	6 (−2)

- **Saving Throws** Str −2, Dex +2, Con +1, Int −3, Wis +1, Cha −2
- **Skills** Perception +5
- **Resistances** Bludgeoning, Piercing, Slashing
- **Immunities** Charmed, Frightened, Grappled, Paralyzed, Petrified, Prone, Restrained, Stunned
- **Senses** Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1/4 (XP 50; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Swarm.*** The swarm can occupy another creature's space and vice versa, and the swarm can move through any opening large enough for a Tiny raven. The swarm can't regain Hit Points or gain Temporary Hit Points.

Actions

- ***Beaks.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage, or 2 (1d4) Piercing damage if the swarm is Bloodied.
- ***Cacophony (Recharge 6).*** *Wisdom Saving Throw:* DC 10, one creature in the swarm's space. *Failure:* The target has the Deafened condition until the start of the swarm's next turn. While Deafened, the target also has Disadvantage on ability checks and attack rolls.

Attack 1: Outside Millbrook

Act 1, Day 1. Low difficulty (450 XP for four level 3 characters).

Less than an hour out of Millbrook, the Crows block the road and demand the Rook's toll. This is a test: they want to see who is guarding the caravan and how well they fight.

Setup

The road climbs out of the river valley between hedgerows and a stony hillside. Around a bend, a handcart lies on its side across the road. Six bandits stand behind it with crossbows. Their leader, a big, cheerful thug called **Gully**, steps forward with his hands open.

> "*Morning! This is the Rook's road now, friends. Toll's one wagon in three, or fifty gold a wagon, your pick. Marsh Freight was told already. Last chance.*"

Two **scouts** lie hidden on the hillside 60 feet above the road (Stealth +6; spotting them takes a Wisdom (Perception) check against DC 16, or a passive Perception of 16 or higher). They open fire if a fight starts.

Tobin refuses to pay. He's been told about the toll before and won't give in. Unless the party comes up with another plan, the fight starts.

Tactics

- The bandits shoot from behind the cart (Half Cover, +2 AC) and only close in to melee when a character reaches them.
- Gully closes in to melee and uses Pack Tactics.
- The scouts shoot at whoever looks most dangerous, then at the horses (AC 10, HP 15) to stop the wagons.
- **Morale.** When Gully goes down or half the Crows are out of the fight, the rest scatter into the hills. They are testing the party, not making a last stand.

Talking instead

Paying the toll ends the encounter, but Tobin is furious, and the Crows will be back at the midpoint anyway (the Rook wants to make an example of Marsh Freight). A character who succeeds on a DC 15 Charisma (Intimidation) check, after showing some real force, makes Gully back down for today.

What the party can learn

- **A captured bandit** knows that the Crows work for the Rook, a warlord who wants to control "every coin that moves between the two towns". They know Marsh Freight refused to pay and is to be made an example of. They also know a lieutenant called **Sable** is waiting farther down the road. They don't know where the Rook's fort is; only Sable's crew go there.
- **Every Crow** wears a black feather threaded through a copper ring stamped with a squat tower. This **crow-feather token** comes up again in Act 2.

Scaling

- **Weaker party (level 1–2):** Remove the scouts and two bandits (200 XP).
- **Stronger party (level 4–5):** Add two toughs and two bandits, and give Gully the Tough Boss stat block (SRD 5.2) instead.

Stat blocks

Bandit (6)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +1, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Light Crossbow, Scimitar
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 1/8 (XP 25; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +3, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) Slashing damage.
- ***Light Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 80/320 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) Piercing damage.

Gully (Tough) (1)

Gully uses the Tough stat block with no changes.

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 32 (5d8 + 10)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +2, Dex +1, Con +2, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Heavy Crossbow, Leather Armor, Mace
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The tough has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the tough's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Mace.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Bludgeoning damage.
- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d10 + 1) Piercing damage.

Scout (2)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 13 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 16 (3d8 + 3)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +2, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +1, Cha +0
- **Skills** Nature +4, Perception +5, Stealth +6, Survival +5
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Longbow, Shortsword
- **Senses** Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The scout makes two attacks, using Shortsword and Longbow in any combination.
- ***Shortsword.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage.
- ***Longbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 150/600 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) Piercing damage.

Gully (Tough Boss) (stronger party only)

For a party of level 4–5, Gully uses this stat block instead of the Tough.

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 16 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 82 (11d8 + 33)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
17 (+3)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +5, Dex +2, Con +5, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +2
- **Gear** Chain Mail, Heavy Crossbow, Warhammer
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 4 (XP 1,100; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The tough has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the tough's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The tough makes two attacks, using Warhammer or Heavy Crossbow in any combination.
- ***Warhammer.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 12 (2d8 + 3) Bludgeoning damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, the tough pushes the target up to 10 feet straight away from itself.
- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 13 (2d10 + 2) Piercing damage.

Encounter tracker

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Gully (tough; as Tough Boss for a stronger party: AC 16, HP 82)	12	32			
Bandit 1	12	11			
Bandit 2	12	11			
Bandit 3	12	11			
Bandit 4	12	11			
Bandit 5	12	11			
Bandit 6	12	11			
Scout 1	13	16			
Scout 2	13	16			
Tough 1 (stronger party only)	12	32			
Tough 2 (stronger party only)	12	32			
Bandit 7 (stronger party only)	12	11			
Bandit 8 (stronger party only)	12	11			

Attack 2: The Midway Ambush

Act 1, Day 2. Moderate difficulty (950 XP for four level 3 characters).

In the middle of the Ashwood, the road crosses a shallow river at Crow's Ford. The Rook's lieutenant, **Sable**, has set a real ambush here to make an example of Marsh Freight. **Tobin Marsh is killed in the first volley.**

Setup

The ford is 40 feet wide and knee-deep, with a gravel bed. Water and mud count as Difficult Terrain, and the wagons can only move at a crawl. On the far bank, a freshly felled tree lies across the road. Thick woods come down to the water on both sides.

- **Far bank:** Sable, two toughs, and two bandits are hidden behind the fallen tree (Half Cover).
- **Near bank:** Two bandits wait in the trees behind the caravan to cut off its retreat.
- **Up in the trees:** Two scouts, one on each bank, are 15 feet up (Three-Quarters Cover, +5 AC). Climbing to them is a DC 12 Strength (Athletics) check.

Spotting the ambush before it starts takes a Wisdom (Perception) check against DC 16. A success means the noticing character isn't Surprised. **It does not save Tobin**; see below.

The driver's death

This death is scripted. Run it as narration, not as dice rolls.

> *As the lead wagon rolls into the water, crossbows snap from the far bank. Every bolt flies at the driver's bench. Tobin jerks and slumps sideways. The reins slide from his hands into the river.*

Tobin is dying. Any healing magic or a DC 10 Wisdom (Medicine) check keeps him conscious just long enough to speak once the fight is over. He does not survive. His last words:

> *"Tell Hester... I wouldn't pay. Tell her it was Sable. The tower on the feathers. Don't let him win."*

Make it clear the party couldn't have prevented this. On the Rook's orders, Sable aimed every crossbow at Tobin, to show what happens to anyone who refuses the toll.

Tactics

- In the first round, the bandits and toughs fire at Tobin (see above). From then on they fire at the party.
- Sable stays behind the tree, shouts orders, and fires her hand crossbow. She only moves into melee to finish off a weakened character.
- The near-bank bandits attack the rear wagon's teamsters if nobody is guarding them. This pulls the party in two directions.
- **Morale.** When Sable is Bloodied (26 HP or fewer), she runs for a horse tethered 100 feet into the woods on the far bank, and the rest of the Crows scatter. If she gets away, she leads Attack 3.

Talking instead

Sable doesn't negotiate. She has her orders. A captured Crow can be questioned after the fight.

What the party can learn

- **Sable's saddlebag** (if she is caught, or a DC 13 Wisdom (Survival) check follows her trail back to the horse before she reaches it) holds a **toll ledger**. It lists the caravans that paid and the ones that refused, and Marsh Freight is circled. The back page has a rough sketch of a trail leading north from the road into the Ashwood, marked with the same squat tower as the crow-feather tokens. This is the strongest lead for Act 2.
- **A captured Crow** knows Sable is the Rook's right hand and that she reports to "the old fort in the woods". They don't know the way there; scouts guide the new recruits.

Scaling

- **Weaker party (level 1–2):** Remove the two scouts and both toughs. Give Sable 30 HP and have her flee when she drops to 15 HP (550 XP).
- **Stronger party (level 4–5):** Add two toughs and two more scouts (1,350 XP).

Stat blocks

Sable (Bandit Captain) (1)

Sable is built from the SRD 5.2 Bandit Captain. **Change:** her Pistol is replaced with a Hand Crossbow, so she fits settings without firearms. If your setting has firearms, give her back the Pistol (*Ranged Attack Roll:* +5, range 30/90 ft. *Hit:* 8 (1d10 + 3) Piercing damage).

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 15 · **Initiative** +3 (13)
- **HP** 52 (8d8 + 16)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +4, Dex +5, Con +2, Int +2, Wis +2, Cha +2
- **Skills** Athletics +4, Deception +4
- **Gear** Hand Crossbow, Scimitar, Studded Leather Armor
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 2 (XP 450; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** Sable makes two attacks, using Scimitar and Hand Crossbow in any combination.
- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) Slashing damage.
- ***Hand Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +5, range 30/120 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) Piercing damage.

Reactions

- ***Parry.*** *Trigger:* Sable is hit by a melee attack roll while holding a weapon. *Response:* Sable adds 2 to her AC against that attack, possibly causing it to miss.

Tough (2)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 32 (5d8 + 10)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +2, Dex +1, Con +2, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Heavy Crossbow, Leather Armor, Mace
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common

- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The tough has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the tough's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Mace.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Bludgeoning damage.
- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d10 + 1) Piercing damage.

Bandit (4)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +1, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Light Crossbow, Scimitar
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 1/8 (XP 25; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +3, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) Slashing damage.
- ***Light Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 80/320 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) Piercing damage.

Scout (2)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 13 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 16 (3d8 + 3)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +2, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +1, Cha +0
- **Skills** Nature +4, Perception +5, Stealth +6, Survival +5
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Longbow, Shortsword
- **Senses** Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The scout makes two attacks, using Shortsword and Longbow in any combination.
- ***Shortsword.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage.
- ***Longbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 150/600 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) Piercing damage.

Encounter tracker

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Sable (bandit captain)	15	52			
Tough 1 (far bank)	12	32			
Tough 2 (far bank)	12	32			
Bandit 1 (far bank)	12	11			
Bandit 2 (far bank)	12	11			
Bandit 3 (near bank)	12	11			
Bandit 4 (near bank)	12	11			
Scout 1 (far tree)	13	16			
Scout 2 (near tree)	13	16			
Tough 3 (stronger party only)	12	32			
Tough 4 (stronger party only)	12	32			
Scout 3 (stronger party only)	13	16			
Scout 4 (stronger party only)	13	16			

Attack 3: Before Harrowgate

Act 1, Day 3. Low to Moderate difficulty (500 XP, or 950 XP if Sable leads).

On the last hill before Harrowgate, with the town walls in sight, the Crows try once more. This time they aren't trying to rob the caravan. They want to **burn it**, so everyone in Harrowgate sees what happens to anyone who defies the Rook.

Setup

The road drops through a sunken lane, a cutting 10 feet deep and 15 feet wide with steep earth banks. At the bottom, a hay cart has been dragged across the road and set alight. Crows wait on top of both banks with torches and crossbows.

- **Climbing a bank** takes a DC 12 Strength (Athletics) check or 10 feet of extra movement for each 5 feet climbed.
- Characters in the lane are 10 feet below the Crows, who have Half Cover along the bank tops.
- **The burning cart** blocks the road. Moving it takes a DC 14 Strength (Athletics) check (a character who enters its space or starts their turn there takes 3 (1d6) Fire damage). Two characters working together have Advantage.

Who leads: If Sable escaped Attack 2, she leads this attack and wants revenge. If not, the toughs are leaderless and quicker to break.

Burning the wagons

As an action, a bandit or tough within 30 feet of a wagon can throw a torch at it (*Ranged Attack Roll:* +3 against AC 10). On a hit, the wagon catches fire.

- A burning wagon is destroyed, with its cargo, at the end of its third round on fire.
- A character can use an action to put out a burning wagon: smother it with a tarp, beat out the flames, or throw water on it. That ends the fire.
- The teamsters will cut the horses free, but they won't fight.

Hester Marsh notes any lost wagons when the caravan reaches Harrowgate, but doesn't hold them against the party (see Act 2).

Help from Harrowgate

The teamster Petra carries a signal horn. If someone blows it (an action), the Harrowgate gate watch sees the smoke, hears the horn, and rides out. Six guards arrive at the start of the fifth round, and any Crows still standing flee.

Tactics

- In round 1, the bandits throw torches at the wagons while the toughs and the scout shoot at the party.
- The Crows on top of the banks stay there. They only come down to finish off a downed character.
- Sable, if she is here, targets whoever stopped her at the ford.
- **Morale.** The Crows flee when half of them are down or when the guards arrive. If Sable leads, she fights until she is Bloodied (26 HP or fewer), then flees.

What the party can learn

- **Tracks.** The Crows didn't come along the road. A DC 12 Wisdom (Survival) check shows a well-used trail heading north toward the eastern edge of the Ashwood. It leads to Brannoc's camp in Act 2.
- **A captured Crow** is frightened and will trade what they know for their life: the Crows at this end of the road come from a camp in the woods to the north, run by a lieutenant called Brannoc. They don't know where the Rook himself is; only Brannoc goes there.

Scaling

- **Weaker party (level 1–2):** Remove two toughs. If Sable leads, use her weaker version from Attack 2 (30 HP).
- **Stronger party (level 4–5):** Add two toughs and a scout. If Sable doesn't lead, a tough boss leads instead.

Stat blocks

Sable (Bandit Captain) (1, only if she escaped Attack 2)

Sable is built from the SRD 5.2 Bandit Captain. **Change:** her Pistol is replaced with a Hand Crossbow. If your setting has firearms, give her back the Pistol (*Ranged Attack Roll:* +5, range 30/90 ft. *Hit:* 8 (1d10 + 3) Piercing damage). Use her current HP from Attack 2 if she didn't have time to rest.

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 15 · **Initiative** +3 (13)
- **HP** 52 (8d8 + 16)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +4, Dex +5, Con +2, Int +2, Wis +2, Cha +2
- **Skills** Athletics +4, Deception +4
- **Gear** Hand Crossbow, Scimitar, Studded Leather Armor
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 2 (XP 450; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** Sable makes two attacks, using Scimitar and Hand Crossbow in any combination.
- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) Slashing damage.
- ***Hand Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +5, range 30/120 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) Piercing damage.

Reactions

- ***Parry.*** *Trigger:* Sable is hit by a melee attack roll while holding a weapon. *Response:* Sable adds 2 to her AC against that attack, possibly causing it to miss.

Tough (3)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 32 (5d8 + 10)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +2, Dex +1, Con +2, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Heavy Crossbow, Leather Armor, Mace
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The tough has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the tough's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Mace.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Bludgeoning damage.
- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d10 + 1) Piercing damage.

Bandit (4)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +1, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Light Crossbow, Scimitar
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 1/8 (XP 25; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +3, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) Slashing damage.
- ***Light Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 80/320 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) Piercing damage.

Scout (1)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 13 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 16 (3d8 + 3)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +2, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +1, Cha +0
- **Skills** Nature +4, Perception +5, Stealth +6, Survival +5
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Longbow, Shortsword
- **Senses** Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The scout makes two attacks, using Shortsword and Longbow in any combination.
- ***Shortsword.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage.
- ***Longbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 150/600 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) Piercing damage.

Tough Boss (1, stronger party only, when Sable doesn't lead)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 16 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 82 (11d8 + 33)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
17 (+3)	14 (+2)	16 (+3)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +5, Dex +2, Con +5, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +2
- **Gear** Chain Mail, Heavy Crossbow, Warhammer
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 4 (XP 1,100; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The tough has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the tough's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The tough makes two attacks, using Warhammer or Heavy Crossbow in any combination.

- ***Warhammer.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 12 (2d8 + 3) Bludgeoning damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, the tough pushes the target up to 10 feet straight away from itself.
- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 13 (2d10 + 2) Piercing damage.

Encounter tracker

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Sable (bandit captain; if she escaped Attack 2)	15	52			
Tough 1 (north bank)	12	32			
Tough 2 (south bank)	12	32			
Tough 3 (south bank)	12	32			
Bandit 1 (north bank)	12	11			
Bandit 2 (north bank)	12	11			
Bandit 3 (south bank)	12	11			
Bandit 4 (south bank)	12	11			
Scout 1	13	16			
Tough 4 (stronger party only)	12	32			
Tough 5 (stronger party only)	12	32			
Scout 2 (stronger party only)	13	16			
Tough boss (stronger party, no Sable)	16	82			

Wagon	AC	Rounds on fire (destroyed at 3)
Wagon 1 (Tobin's)	10	
Wagon 2	10	
Wagon 3	10	

Road Encounters

Act 1, optional. Random encounters on the Old Trade Road.

The road between Millbrook and Harrowgate runs through farmland, the Ashwood, and open hills. Use this table to add danger between the three Crow attacks.

When to roll

Roll a d6 once each day and once each night of the journey. On a 1, roll on the table below, or pick an entry that suits the moment.

The party already faces three scripted attacks, so **use no more than one random encounter a day** for a party of level 3. Keep the fights short. Their job is to wear down resources and break up the travel, not to replace the Crows.

Road encounters (d8)

d8	Encounter	XP (4 × level 3)	Where
1	Wolf pack: 4 wolves	200 (Low)	Anywhere, usually at night
2	Dire wolf: 1 dire wolf and 2 wolves	300 (Low)	Hills or Ashwood, night
3	Wild boars: 4 boars	200 (Low)	Farmland or Ashwood
4	Brown bear: 1 brown bear	200 (Low)	Ashwood
5	Giant spiders: 2 giant spiders	400 (Low)	Ashwood only; reroll elsewhere
6	Goblin raiders: 4 goblin warriors and a goblin boss	400 (Low)	Hills
7	Ravens on the dead: 3 swarms of ravens	150 (Low)	Anywhere
8	The robbed peddler: no fight	—	Anywhere

1. Wolf pack

Four hungry wolves circle the camp after dark, looking for a horse to take. They go for the picketed horses first and fight anyone who gets between them and the herd. When two wolves are down, the rest flee.

- **Weaker party:** 2 wolves. **Stronger party:** 6 wolves, or add a dire wolf.

2. Dire wolf

A dire wolf and two wolves stalk the caravan, staying at the edge of the light. A DC 13 Wisdom (Perception) check spots their eyes before they rush in. The dire wolf knocks a target Prone, and the wolves pile on with Pack Tactics. The pack flees if the dire wolf dies.

- **Weaker party:** the dire wolf alone. **Stronger party:** 2 dire wolves and 2 wolves.

3. Wild boars

A sounder of boars bursts out of the undergrowth across the road, and the wagon horses panic. The driver of each wagon makes a DC 12 Wisdom (Animal Handling) check (a character can take the reins and make it instead); on a failure, the wagon lurches off the road and is stuck until someone spends 10 minutes freeing it. The boars charge anyone nearby, then scatter when two are down.

- **Weaker party:** 2 boars. **Stronger party:** 6 boars.

4. Brown bear

A brown bear is feeding on a dead deer in the middle of the road. It won't give up the carcass. The party can go around it through the trees (an hour's delay to clear a path for the wagons), drive it off (a DC 15 Wisdom (Animal Handling) or Charisma (Intimidation) check, or offering it food), or fight it. Once it drops to half its HP (11), it lumbers away.

- **Weaker party:** the bear flees at 15 HP. **Stronger party:** 2 brown bears (a mother and a grown cub).

5. Giant spiders

Thick webs stretch between the trees across the road, with old wrapped bundles hanging from them. Two giant spiders wait in the branches above (spotting them takes a Wisdom (Perception) check against DC 17, or a passive Perception of 17 or higher). Clearing the web for the wagons takes 10 minutes or some fire. The spiders attack whoever touches the web first. One bundle holds a dead traveler wearing a crow-feather token: a Crow who wandered off from the gang.

- **Weaker party:** 1 giant spider. **Stronger party:** 3 giant spiders.

6. Goblin raiders

A goblin war band has come down from the hills, trying to get its share of the road before the Crows take all of it. Four goblin warriors shoot from the rocks, using Nimble Escape to hide between shots, while the goblin boss waits for an opening to grab a crate. The goblins

hate the Crows. A captured goblin will happily say that "the tower men" drove the goblins out of the deep Ashwood, and point north into the trees.

- **Weaker party:** 3 goblin warriors and no boss. **Stronger party:** 6 goblin warriors and the boss.

7. Ravens on the dead

A wrecked wagon lies beside the road with dead travelers, a family that wouldn't pay the toll. Flocks of ravens are feeding on them and rise screaming at anyone who comes near. The wreck carries a painted warning: **"PAY THE ROOK."** The party can bury the dead. A DC 10 Wisdom (Insight) check makes it clear the teamsters are badly shaken; their morale is low for the rest of the trip.

- **Weaker party:** 2 swarms. **Stronger party:** 5 swarms.

8. The robbed peddler

A tinker named Oda walks the road toward Millbrook, leading a donkey with empty saddlebags. The Crows took everything she had. She tells the party that the Crows "have eyes all along the road", that a lieutenant called Sable runs the ambushes, and that the Rook "thinks he's a king, and the rest of us are his peasants". If the party gives her food or coin, she adds that she has seen lanterns flashing in the treetops deep in the Ashwood at night, like signals.

Stat blocks

Wolf (entries 1 and 2)

Medium Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 40 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
14 (+2)	15 (+2)	12 (+1)	3 (−4)	12 (+1)	6 (−2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +2, Dex +2, Con +1, Int −4, Wis +1, Cha −2
- **Skills** Perception +5, Stealth +4
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1/4 (XP 50; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The wolf has Advantage on attack rolls against a creature if at least one of the wolf's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Bite.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage. If the target is a Medium or smaller creature, it has the Prone condition.

Dire Wolf (entry 2)

Large Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 14 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 22 (3d10 + 6)
- **Speed** 50 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
17 (+3)	15 (+2)	15 (+2)	3 (−4)	12 (+1)	7 (−2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +3, Dex +2, Con +2, Int −4, Wis +1, Cha −2
- **Skills** Perception +5, Stealth +4
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The wolf has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the wolf's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Bite.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 8 (1d10 + 3) Piercing damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, it has the Prone condition.

Boar (entry 3)

Medium Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 11 · **Initiative** +0 (10)
- **HP** 13 (2d8 + 4)
- **Speed** 40 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
13 (+1)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)	2 (−4)	9 (−1)	5 (−3)

- **Saving Throws** Str +1, Dex +0, Con +2, Int −4, Wis −1, Cha −3
- **Senses** Passive Perception 9
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1/4 (XP 50; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Bloodied Fury.*** While Bloodied, the boar has Advantage on attack rolls.

Actions

- ***Gore.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +3, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) Piercing damage. If the target is a Medium or smaller creature and the boar moved 20+ feet straight toward it immediately before the hit, the target takes an extra 3 (1d6) Piercing damage and has the Prone condition.

Brown Bear (entry 4)

Large Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 11 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 22 (3d10 + 6)
- **Speed** 40 ft., Climb 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
17 (+3)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	2 (−4)	13 (+1)	7 (−2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +3, Dex +1, Con +2, Int −4, Wis +1, Cha −2
- **Skills** Perception +3
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 13
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The bear makes one Bite attack and one Claw attack.
- ***Bite.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) Piercing damage.
- ***Claw.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) Slashing damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, it has the Prone condition.

Giant Spider (entry 5)

Large Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 14 · **Initiative** +3 (13)
- **HP** 26 (4d10 + 4)
- **Speed** 30 ft., Climb 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
14 (+2)	16 (+3)	12 (+1)	2 (−4)	11 (+0)	4 (−3)

- **Saving Throws** Str +2, Dex +3, Con +1, Int −4, Wis +0, Cha −3
- **Skills** Perception +4, Stealth +7
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 14
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Spider Climb.*** The spider can climb difficult surfaces, including along ceilings, without needing to make an ability check.
- ***Web Walker.*** The spider ignores movement restrictions caused by webs, and it knows the location of any other creature in contact with the same web.

Actions

- ***Bite.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) Piercing damage plus 7 (2d6) Poison damage.
- ***Web (Recharge 5–6).*** *Dexterity Saving Throw:* DC 13, one creature the spider can see within 60 feet. *Failure:* The target has the Restrained condition until the web is destroyed (AC 10; HP 5; Vulnerability to Fire damage; Immunity to Poison and Psychic damage).

Goblin Warrior (entry 6)

Small Fey (Goblinoid), Chaotic Neutral

- **AC** 15 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 10 (3d6)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
8 (−1)	15 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	8 (−1)	8 (−1)

- **Saving Throws** Str −1, Dex +2, Con +0, Int +0, Wis −1, Cha −1

- **Skills** Stealth +6
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Scimitar, Shield, Shortbow
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 9
- **Languages** Common, Goblin
- **CR** 1/4 (XP 50; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Slashing damage, plus 2 (1d4) Slashing damage if the attack roll had Advantage.
- ***Shortbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 80/320 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage, plus 2 (1d4) Piercing damage if the attack roll had Advantage.

Bonus Actions

- ***Nimble Escape.*** The goblin takes the Disengage or Hide action.

Goblin Boss (entry 6)

Small Fey (Goblinoid), Chaotic Neutral

- **AC** 17 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 21 (6d6)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
10 (+0)	15 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	8 (−1)	10 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +2, Con +0, Int +0, Wis −1, Cha +0
- **Skills** Stealth +6
- **Gear** Chain Shirt, Scimitar, Shield, Shortbow
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 9
- **Languages** Common, Goblin
- **CR** 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The goblin makes two attacks, using Scimitar or Shortbow in any combination.
- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Slashing damage, plus 2 (1d4) Slashing damage if the attack roll had Advantage.
- ***Shortbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 80/320 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage, plus 2 (1d4) Piercing damage if the attack roll had Advantage.

Bonus Actions

- ***Nimble Escape.*** The goblin takes the Disengage or Hide action.

Reactions

- ***Redirect Attack.*** *Trigger:* A creature the goblin can see makes an attack roll against it. *Response:* The goblin chooses a Small or Medium ally within 5 feet of itself. The goblin and that ally swap places, and the ally becomes the target of the attack instead.

Swarm of Ravens (entry 7)

Medium Swarm of Tiny Beasts, Unaligned

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 10 ft., Fly 50 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
6 (−2)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	5 (−3)	12 (+1)	6 (−2)

- **Saving Throws** Str −2, Dex +2, Con +1, Int −3, Wis +1, Cha −2
- **Skills** Perception +5
- **Resistances** Bludgeoning, Piercing, Slashing
- **Immunities** Charmed, Frightened, Grappled, Paralyzed, Petrified, Prone, Restrained, Stunned
- **Senses** Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1/4 (XP 50; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Swarm.*** The swarm can occupy another creature's space and vice versa, and the swarm can move through any opening large enough for a Tiny raven. The swarm can't regain Hit Points or gain Temporary Hit Points.

Actions

- ***Beaks.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage, or 2 (1d4) Piercing damage if the swarm is Bloodied.
- ***Cacophony (Recharge 6).*** *Wisdom Saving Throw:* DC 10, one creature in the swarm's space. *Failure:* The target has the Deafened condition until the start of the swarm's next turn. While Deafened, the target also has Disadvantage on ability checks and attack rolls.

Encounter tracker

Use the table for the entry you rolled. Rows marked "stronger party" are for the scaled-up version.

1. Wolf pack

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Wolf 1	12	11			
Wolf 2	12	11			
Wolf 3	12	11			
Wolf 4	12	11			
Wolf 5 (stronger party)	12	11			
Wolf 6 (stronger party)	12	11			

2. Dire wolf

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Dire wolf 1	14	22			
Wolf 1	12	11			
Wolf 2	12	11			
Dire wolf 2 (stronger party)	14	22			

3. Wild boars

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Boar 1	11	13			
Boar 2	11	13			
Boar 3	11	13			
Boar 4	11	13			
Boar 5 (stronger party)	11	13			
Boar 6 (stronger party)	11	13			

4. Brown bear

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Brown bear 1	11	22			

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Brown bear 2 (stronger party)	11	22			

5. Giant spiders

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Giant spider 1	14	26			
Giant spider 2	14	26			
Giant spider 3 (stronger party)	14	26			

6. Goblin raiders

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Goblin boss	17	21			
Goblin warrior 1	15	10			
Goblin warrior 2	15	10			
Goblin warrior 3	15	10			
Goblin warrior 4	15	10			
Goblin warrior 5 (stronger party)	15	10			
Goblin warrior 6 (stronger party)	15	10			

7. Ravens on the dead

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Swarm of ravens 1	12	11			
Swarm of ravens 2	12	11			
Swarm of ravens 3	12	11			
Swarm of ravens 4 (stronger party)	12	11			
Swarm of ravens 5 (stronger party)	12	11			

Act 2: The Trail

Session 2. Level 3.

The party arrives in Harrowgate and meets Hester Marsh, whose reaction, and the party's bonus, depend on what they did with Tobin's body. After a night at the Iron Harrow inn, Hester and Captain Roderick Vane of the town guard ask the party to find out why the Crows are attacking so often. In the town jail, the party questions a captured Crow in a skill challenge and learns of Brannoc, a Crow lieutenant camped in the Ashwood who knows the way to the Rook's fort. On the way to his camp, they meet a brown bear. By keeping Brannoc alive to question him, or by finding his hidden stash of documents, the party learns that the Rook sees himself as a king and that his base is Ashwatch, an old fort deep in the woods. Then they set out for it.

Place in the story

- **Comes from:** Act 1: The Caravan.
- **Leads to:** Act 3: The Bandit Lord. The party knows where the fort is and how it is guarded, and may have prisoners, a disguise, or an inside contact.

Adventures

1. Following the Trail

Encounters

1. The Bear: Low, 200 XP
2. The Crow Camp: Moderate, 900 XP
3. The Lookout Post: to be written

Following the Trail

Act 2. One session. Four or five characters of level 3.

The party reaches Harrowgate with the caravan and meets Tobin's cousin, Hester Marsh. How she receives them depends on what they did with Tobin's body. After a night at the Iron Harrow inn, Hester and the captain of the town guard ask the party to find out why the Crows' attacks have grown so frequent, and where the Crows are coming from.

Background

Until a year ago, the road between Millbrook and Harrowgate had the usual trouble: a robbery now and then, a stolen horse. Then a warlord who calls himself **the Rook** took over Ashwatch, an old toll fort on an abandoned road deep in the Ashwood, and gathered the scattered bandits of the region into one gang, the Crows. Every gang that wouldn't join him was wiped out.

Why the attacks have grown (the truth for the DM): The Rook wants to be the only boss in the region: every gang, merchant, and town paying him and answering to him. He sees himself as a king. He calls himself the King of the Ashwood, sits on a throne in the fort's old toll hall, and calls the Crows his court. His gang has grown from a dozen to about forty, and he must feed and pay them all, so he needs more toll every month. Marsh Freight's refusal to pay is a challenge to his rule, which is why he ordered Tobin made an example of.

Cast

Name	Who they are	At the table
Hester Marsh	Head of Marsh Freight; Tobin's cousin. Forties, ink-stained fingers, sharp eyes.	Grieving but practical. Wants the road back, not revenge. Her warmth toward the party depends on how they treated Tobin.
Captain Roderick Vane	Captain of the Harrowgate guard. Sixties, grey-bearded, limps from an old wound.	Honest and tired. Has twenty guards to protect a town and three days of road. Blunt, and grateful for help.
Morwen Tull	Keeper of the Iron Harrow inn.	Talkative, knows every rumor in town, keeps the best rooms for guests who tip.
Petra	Teamster from the caravan.	Stays in Harrowgate. Can vouch for the party to Hester and the captain.
Jory Fennick	A young Crow in the town jail; son of old Fennick the stablemaster.	Scared, regretful, more afraid of the Rook than the hangman. Knows where Brannoc's camp is.

Name	Who they are	At the table
Brannoc, "the Magpie"	Crow lieutenant with a camp in the Ashwood.	Vain, clever, greedy, covered in stolen rings. Fears the Rook and fights hard, but talks if he's taken alive.

1. Arrival in Harrowgate

Harrowgate is a walled market town at the east end of the Old Trade Road. The caravan arrives at the west gate as the lamps are being lit. Marsh Freight's yard is just inside.

Hester Marsh comes out to meet the caravan, sees Petra on the lead wagon, and understands before anyone speaks.

> *She stands very still. "Where is he?" Then, quieter: "Did he pay them?"*

Hester listens to the whole story without interrupting. Then she pays the party what Tobin promised: 40 gp each, or 50 gp if they negotiated a better fee.

Hester's reaction

What Hester does next depends on what the party did with Tobin's body in Act 1.

The party...	Hester's reaction	Bonus
Carried his body to Harrowgate with care	She goes to the wagon, lifts the cloth from his face, and stays with him a long moment. When she turns back, her eyes are wet but steady. "You brought him home. I won't forget that." She invites the party to the burial at dawn the day after tomorrow, and from now on she trusts them completely.	**25 gp each**, and **150 XP each** (or Heroic Inspiration for each character, if you use milestone levelling)
Buried him by the road	She asks exactly where, and nods. "Then he's resting on the road he loved. I'll bring him home myself when it's safe." She is grateful, if quieter.	**10 gp each**
Left his body	She says nothing for a long moment. "I see." She pays the agreed fee, exactly, and turns away. Next morning she is cool and businesslike with the party. She still needs them, but they will have to earn her trust.	**None**

Other things the party can give Hester:

- **Tobin's last words** ("Tell Hester... I wouldn't pay. Tell her it was Sable..."). Her grief turns to resolve.

- **The wooden horse** for her daughter, Lissy. She has to step away for a moment. If the party left Tobin's body, but brings her the horse, she softens a little: "So you didn't forget him entirely."
- **Lost wagons.** If wagons were burned, Hester notes it but doesn't hold it against the party. "Salt can be bought. Tobin can't."

Hester tells the party she has rooms paid for them at the Iron Harrow, and asks them to meet her there in the morning. "There's someone you should talk to. Get some sleep."

2. The night at the Iron Harrow

The **Iron Harrow** is a solid stone inn on Harrowgate's market square, named for the old iron harrow blade bolted above its door. Hester has paid for the party's rooms, meals, and baths for as long as they work for her.

The common room is busy, and the talk is all about the Crows. Morwen Tull, the innkeeper, is happy to talk to people who have actually fought them. Each character who spends some time in the common room hears one rumor (roll a d6 or choose).

d6	Rumor	True?
1	"Half the council wants to pay the Rook just to make it stop."	True
2	"There were barely a dozen Crows last spring. Now they say there's forty, maybe more."	True
3	"The Rook's a fallen knight. Or a dragon in disguise. Depends who you ask."	False
4	"Woodcutters say they see lanterns flashing in the treetops deep in the Ashwood at night."	True: the Crows' lookouts signal to the fort
5	"Old Fennick's boy went off to join the Crows. Says the pay's better than mucking stables."	True: the Rook is recruiting
6	"There's an old toll fort deep in the Ashwood, on the forest road they abandoned fifty years ago. Nobody goes there anymore."	True, but someone does now

The feather on the door. In the morning, the party finds a crow-feather token nailed to one of their doors. Nobody saw who left it. The Rook knows who they are.

3. The morning meeting

Over breakfast in a private room at the Iron Harrow, Hester (dressed in mourning) introduces **Captain Roderick Vane** of the Harrowgate guard.

> *The captain lowers himself into a chair with a grunt and sets a battered map case on the table. "Mistress Marsh tells me you've met the Crows. Three times in three days. That's more than my whole watch has managed in a year."*

Captain Vane is blunt about the problem:

- A year ago, the road saw an attack every month or two. In the last three months, there have been **fourteen attacks**, and they are getting bolder.
- He has twenty guards to protect the town walls, the market, and the jail. He can't patrol three days of road, let alone the Ashwood.
- The town council is split. Some councillors want to pay the Rook's toll just to keep trade moving. Vane thinks that would only be the start: "You pay a man like that once, and he owns you."
- He doesn't know where the Crows are based, how many there are, or why they have suddenly grown so bold.

The request. Hester and the captain ask the party to **find out why the bandits are attacking so much, and where they are coming from**. Once the party knows that, the town can decide what to do, and if the party can end the threat themselves, so much the better.

The offer:

- **The council's bounty:** 200 gp for proof that the Crows are broken (the Rook captured or dead, or the gang scattered).
- **Marsh Freight** adds 100 gp, and meals and rooms at the Iron Harrow for as long as the job takes.
- **Captain Vane** gives the party a writ naming them as deputies of the Harrowgate guard. It lets them question prisoners in the town jail and requisition mounts and supplies from the guard stables.

What they can give the party to start: Vane's map case holds a map of the region marked with every attack in the last year. The marks crowd closer to Harrowgate month by month, and none are north of the road. If the party has a captured Crow, Vane has them in the jail. If the party has no leads at all, he has a Crow his guards caught last week.

4. The prisoner

Captain Vane takes the party to the town jail beneath the guardhouse. If the party brought a captured Crow from Act 1, that's who they question; use that Crow's own personality with the rules below. Otherwise, the prisoner is **Jory Fennick**, a Crow the guard caught last week.

Jory Fennick is seventeen, skinny, and trying hard to look tough. He's the son of old Fennick the stablemaster (the rumor from the inn). He joined the Crows three months ago for the pay, and he regrets it. He is more afraid of the Rook than of the hangman: "You don't know what he does to talkers."

The interrogation (skill challenge)

The party must convince Jory to talk, using **Charisma (Persuasion)** or **Charisma (Intimidation)** checks.

- **Goal:** 3 successes before 2 failures.
- **DC:** 13.
- **Each check** follows something a character says or does: an offer, a threat, an appeal. Let the players roleplay, then call for the check that fits. A character can't make two checks in a row.
- **Switching approach:** the first check after the party switches between Persuasion and Intimidation has Disadvantage, because Jory doesn't know whom to believe. A deliberate "good cop, bad cop" routine that the players set up in advance avoids this.

Ways to gain Advantage on a check:

- **His father.** If a character mentions old Fennick (from the inn rumor), or learns about him with a DC 12 Wisdom (Insight) check, Persuasion checks have Advantage: "Your father's still waiting for you to come home."
- **Clemency.** Vane's writ lets the party promise Jory a lighter sentence. The first Persuasion check that offers it has Advantage.
- **Proof of strength.** Showing Jory crow-feather tokens taken from dead Crows, or Sable's ledger, gives Advantage on the first Intimidation check: the party is more dangerous than he thought.

Success (3 successes). Jory breaks down and tells them everything he knows:

- A Crow lieutenant called **Brannoc**, "the Magpie", runs a camp in the old charcoal burners' clearing at the eastern edge of the Ashwood, half a day from Harrowgate along the woodcutters' track. His crew raids the Harrowgate end of the road.
- Brannoc has four bandits and a scout in a tree stand. The watch changes at midnight.
- The password: the challenge is "Black wings at dusk", and the reply is "Coin for the Rook".
- "Brannoc knows the way to the Rook's fort. He goes there to report. He knows everything, and he keeps the Rook's letters hidden somewhere in camp. Not in his tent; he's not stupid."

Failure (2 failures). Jory clams up. "I'm not saying anything. Brannoc would gut me." Captain Vane recognizes the name: woodcutters have reported smoke near the old charcoal clearing at the edge of the Ashwood. The party learns where the camp is, but not the

password or the watch change, and finding the clearing takes a DC 13 Wisdom (Survival) check (on a failure, they arrive after dark, tired, and the scout has Advantage on checks to notice them).

Afterward. If the party promised Jory clemency, Vane keeps the promise. If the party used threats or violence beyond what Vane allows (your call), Vane has a quiet word with them about how the Harrowgate guard does things.

5. Into the Ashwood

The woodcutters' track leaves the Old Trade Road a mile west of Harrowgate and winds into the eastern Ashwood. It is half a day's walk to the charcoal burners' clearing, or a couple of hours on the guard's horses.

On the way: The Bear. *Low (200 XP).* At a stream crossing, a brown bear sow is fishing with her two cubs. The party can go around her, calm her (DC 14 Wisdom (Animal Handling)), scare her off, or fight. She flees when she drops to 11 HP. Harming her cubs makes the woods go quiet, and gives the camp's scout Advantage to notice the party.

The camp: The Crow Camp. *Moderate (900 XP).* Brannoc (a warrior veteran), four bandits, and a scout in a tree stand. The party can:

- **sneak in** (Stealth against the scout's passive Perception of 15, with Advantage at the midnight watch change);
- **walk in with the password**, claiming to bring a message from Sable (DC 12 Charisma (Deception) to keep up the story);
- **assault the camp**; or
- **cause a distraction** by setting fire to the tents or scattering the horses.

Brannoc fears the Rook more than the party, so he fights hard. To question him, the party must **keep him alive**: knock him out instead of killing him, or make him surrender once his crew is down. If he dies, the party must find his **hidden stash** of documents instead (DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) or Intelligence (Investigation), 10 minutes per attempt; Crows returning from a raid arrive after the third failed attempt).

What the party learns (from Brannoc or the stash):

- **The Rook wants to be the only boss in the region, and he sees himself as a king.** He calls himself the King of the Ashwood, sits on a throne in his fort's hall, and calls the Crows his court.
- **His base is Ashwatch**, an old toll fort on the abandoned forest road deep in the Ashwood, a day's march north of the camp. A lookout in a ruined watchtower on the old road signals the fort with lanterns and a horn.

From Brannoc himself, the party can also learn that about twenty Crows are at the fort at any time, that an old culvert runs under the east wall, and that Sable is the Rook's right hand.

6. After the camp

The camp is only half a day from Harrowgate, so the party will probably go back before heading deeper into the Ashwood.

- **Captain Vane** takes Brannoc into custody (if he's alive) and hears what the party learned. If they found the stash, he reads the Rook's letters, signed "King of the Ashwood", grimly. "A king. He thinks he's a king." He offers the party **four guards** for the attack on the fort (use the Guard stat block from SRD 5.2), or supplies and horses if they prefer to go alone.
- **Hester Marsh** is told about the stolen goods. She sends wagons to bring them back, and the merchants whose goods are returned add **50 gp** to the party's bounty.
- **The town council**, shown the Rook's letters, stops arguing about paying the toll. Nobody wants to be a self-made king's subject.

7. The road to Ashwatch

To be written.

Planned: the day's march north along the abandoned forest road, the Lookout Post in the ruined watchtower, and the approach to Ashwatch that starts Act 3.

Rewards

- **Hester's bonus:** depends on what the party did with Tobin's body (see Hester's reaction).
- **Brannoc's strongbox:** 85 gp, 140 sp, and three gold rings worth 15 gp each.
- **Returned goods:** 50 gp from grateful merchants.
- **The bounty:** 200 gp from the council and 100 gp from Marsh Freight, paid at the end of Act 3.
- **Experience:** the bear (200 XP, or the same if the party avoids her cleverly) and the Crow camp (900 XP), for the whole party.

Appendix: Stat blocks

All the creatures in Act 2 so far.

Brown Bear

Large Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 11 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 22 (3d10 + 6)
- **Speed** 40 ft., Climb 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
17 (+3)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	2 (−4)	13 (+1)	7 (−2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +3, Dex +1, Con +2, Int −4, Wis +1, Cha −2
- **Skills** Perception +3
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 13
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The bear makes one Bite attack and one Claw attack.
- ***Bite.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) Piercing damage.
- ***Claw.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) Slashing damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, it has the Prone condition.

Brannoc (Warrior Veteran)

Brannoc uses the SRD 5.2 Warrior Veteran stat block with no changes. He also wears three gold rings and carries the key to his strongbox.

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 17 · **Initiative** +3 (13)
- **HP** 65 (10d8 + 20)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
16 (+3)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +3, Dex +1, Con +2, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Skills** Athletics +5, Perception +2
- **Gear** Greatsword, Heavy Crossbow, Splint Armor
- **Senses** Passive Perception 12
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 3 (XP 700; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The warrior makes two Greatsword or Heavy Crossbow attacks.
- ***Greatsword.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 10 (2d6 + 3) Slashing damage.
- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 12 (2d10 + 1) Piercing damage.

Reactions

- ***Parry.*** *Trigger:* The warrior is hit by a melee attack roll while holding a weapon. *Response:* The warrior adds 2 to its AC against that attack, possibly causing it to miss.

Brannoc (Bandit Captain)

For a party of level 1–2, Brannoc uses the SRD 5.2 Bandit Captain stat block instead. **Change:** his Pistol is replaced with a Hand Crossbow.

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 15 · **Initiative** +3 (13)
- **HP** 52 (8d8 + 16)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +4, Dex +5, Con +2, Int +2, Wis +2, Cha +2
- **Skills** Athletics +4, Deception +4
- **Gear** Hand Crossbow, Scimitar, Studded Leather Armor
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 2 (XP 450; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** Brannoc makes two attacks, using Scimitar and Hand Crossbow in any combination.
- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) Slashing damage.
- ***Hand Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +5, range 30/120 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) Piercing damage.

Reactions

- ***Parry.*** *Trigger:* Brannoc is hit by a melee attack roll while holding a weapon. *Response:* Brannoc adds 2 to his AC against that attack, possibly causing it to miss.

Bandit

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +1, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Light Crossbow, Scimitar
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 1/8 (XP 25; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +3, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) Slashing damage.
- ***Light Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 80/320 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) Piercing damage.

Scout

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 13 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 16 (3d8 + 3)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +2, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +1, Cha +0
- **Skills** Nature +4, Perception +5, Stealth +6, Survival +5
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Longbow, Shortsword
- **Senses** Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The scout makes two attacks, using Shortsword and Longbow in any combination.
- ***Shortsword.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage.
- ***Longbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 150/600 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) Piercing damage.

Tough

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 32 (5d8 + 10)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +2, Dex +1, Con +2, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Heavy Crossbow, Leather Armor, Mace
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The tough has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the tough's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Mace.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Bludgeoning damage.
- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d10 + 1) Piercing damage.

The Bear

Act 2, on the way to the Crow camp. Low difficulty (200 XP for four level 3 characters).

On the woodcutters' track to the Crow camp, the party meets a brown bear protecting her cubs. She is dangerous, but the party doesn't have to fight her.

Setup

The track crosses a shallow stream in a gully thick with brambles. A brown bear sow is fishing in the stream, with two cubs splashing in the shallows behind her. The wind is blowing toward the party, so she hasn't smelled them yet.

- A character who succeeds on a DC 12 Wisdom (Perception) check spots the bear before the party walks into the open. Otherwise, the party is 40 feet from her when she rears up and roars.
- The gully sides are steep and thick with brambles. Climbing out is Difficult Terrain.
- The cubs are Tiny and harmless. They run behind their mother.

Avoiding the fight

If the party spots her first or backs off when she roars, the fight can be avoided:

- **Going around:** a detour upstream costs an hour. A DC 12 Wisdom (Survival) check finds the way without losing the track.
- **Calming her:** a DC 14 Wisdom (Animal Handling) check, made by a character who backs away slowly. On a failure, she charges.
- **Food:** throwing her rations or fresh meat gives Advantage on the Animal Handling check.
- **Scaring her off:** fire, a loud noise, or magic, plus a DC 15 Charisma (Intimidation) check. On a success, she herds her cubs away.

Tactics

- The bear attacks anyone who comes within 20 feet of her cubs, or anyone who harms them.
- She doesn't pursue anyone who retreats out of the gully.
- **Morale.** When she drops to 11 HP or fewer, she grabs a cub and lumbers off into the trees.
- **Harming the cubs** turns the party's Crow-camp approach sour: the woods go quiet, and the camp's scout is more alert (Advantage on Perception checks to notice the party).

Scaling

- **Weaker party (level 1–2):** She flees at 15 HP.
- **Stronger party (level 4–5):** Her mate is nearby and joins on round 2 (two brown bears, 400 XP).

Stat blocks

Brown Bear (1)

Large Beast, Unaligned

- **AC** 11 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 22 (3d10 + 6)
- **Speed** 40 ft., Climb 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
17 (+3)	12 (+1)	15 (+2)	2 (−4)	13 (+1)	7 (−2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +3, Dex +1, Con +2, Int −4, Wis +1, Cha −2
- **Skills** Perception +3
- **Senses** Darkvision 60 ft.; Passive Perception 13
- **Languages** None
- **CR** 1 (XP 200; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The bear makes one Bite attack and one Claw attack.
- ***Bite.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 7 (1d8 + 3) Piercing damage.
- ***Claw.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d4 + 3) Slashing damage. If the target is a Large or smaller creature, it has the Prone condition.

Encounter tracker

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Brown bear (sow)	11	22			
Brown bear (mate; stronger party only)	11	22			

The Crow Camp

Act 2. Moderate difficulty (900 XP for four level 3 characters).

At the eastern edge of the Ashwood, half a day from Harrowgate, the Crow lieutenant **Brannoc**, called "the Magpie", runs a forward camp. His crew raids the Harrowgate end of the road. Brannoc knows who the Rook really is and where his fort lies. The party can get that from him if they **keep him alive and question him**, or from the **hidden stash** of documents he keeps in the camp.

Setup

The camp is in an old charcoal burners' clearing, about 80 feet across, ringed by tall trees.

- **Three tents.** Brannoc's large tent is on the north side, with two small tents for his crew.
- **A cookfire** in the middle, where most of the crew spend the evening.
- **Stolen goods** under oiled tarps on the east side: crates and bales, some stamped with Marsh Freight's mark.
- **Four horses** on a picket line on the west side.
- **A tree stand** 20 feet up an oak on the south side, where a **scout** keeps watch (passive Perception 15). Climbing to it takes a DC 12 Strength (Athletics) check.

Who is here: Brannoc, four bandits, and the scout. In the evening, the bandits sit around the fire. After midnight, two of them sleep.

Approaches

How the party approaches depends on what they learned from the prisoner in Following the Trail:

- **Sneaking in:** each character makes a Dexterity (Stealth) check against the scout's passive Perception of 15. If the party knows the watch changes at midnight, they can arrive then and have Advantage on the checks. If everyone succeeds, the party has Surprise.
- **Walking in with the password:** the challenge is "Black wings at dusk", and the reply is "Coin for the Rook". A character who gives the reply and claims to bring a message from Sable gets the party into the camp's clearing. Keeping up the story takes a DC 12 Charisma (Deception) check. If it fails, Brannoc gets suspicious and the fight starts with the party in the middle of the camp.
- **A straight assault:** the scout raises the alarm, and the Crows grab their weapons. Roll initiative normally.

- **Fire or the horses:** setting fire to the tents or scattering the horses (a DC 12 Wisdom (Animal Handling) check or simply cutting the picket line) pulls half the bandits away from the fight for 2 rounds.

If the party harmed the bear's cubs on the way, the scout has Advantage on Perception checks to notice them.

Brannoc, "the Magpie"

Brannoc is the Rook's lieutenant for the Harrowgate end of the road. He's in his forties, lean, with a neat black beard and fingers full of stolen rings. Vain, clever, and greedy, he got his nickname because he can't resist anything shiny. He's loyal to the Rook only as long as it pays. He doesn't want to die for him.

Tactics

- Brannoc fights from in front of his tent with his greatsword. He uses Parry, and calls his crew to surround the party's weakest-looking fighter.
- The bandits fire crossbows from behind the cookfire's woodpile (Half Cover), then close in.
- The scout shoots from the tree stand (Three-Quarters Cover).
- **Morale.** The bandits run when half of them are down. Brannoc fears the Rook more than he fears the party, and he fights hard.

Keeping Brannoc alive

The party has to decide to take Brannoc alive. Remind the players that he's the one who knows the way to the Rook, if they seem to have forgotten.

- **Knocking him out.** A character who reduces Brannoc to 0 Hit Points with a melee attack can knock him out instead of killing him.
- **Making him surrender.** Once all his crew are down or fled and he is Bloodied (32 HP or fewer), a character can use an action to demand his surrender with a DC 15 Charisma (Intimidation) check, or a DC 13 check if they promise him his life. On a success, he drops his sword: "Fine! Fine. You want the Rook? I'll give you the Rook."
- **If Brannoc dies**, the party must find his hidden stash to learn what he knew.

Questioning Brannoc

A captured Brannoc talks to save his own neck. He tells the truth about the things below, but lies about anything that makes him look bad (a DC 13 Wisdom (Insight) check notices when he's lying).

What Brannoc knows

- **What the Rook wants.** "He doesn't want to be a bandit. He wants to be the only boss there is. Every gang in the Ashwood either joined him or ended up in a ditch. Every merchant pays him, and the towns will be next." The Rook sees himself as a king. He calls himself the **King of the Ashwood**, sits on a throne built from the old toll gate in the fort's hall, and makes the Crows kneel and call him "Majesty". "He means it. That's what scares me."
- **Where his base is.** The Rook holds **Ashwatch**, an old toll fort on the forest road that was abandoned fifty years ago, deep in the Ashwood. It's a day's march north of the camp along the overgrown road.
- **The lookout.** An hour short of the fort, a lookout in a ruined watchtower on the old road signals the fort with lanterns by night and a horn by day. If the party doesn't silence it, the fort will be warned.
- **Numbers.** There are about forty Crows. At any time, half of them are out raiding, so twenty or so are in the fort.
- **The way in.** An old drainage culvert runs under the fort's east wall, barred with a rusted iron grate. The password at the gate is the same as at the camp.
- **Sable.** She's the Rook's right hand, and Brannoc hates her. If she's still alive, she's at the fort.

What Brannoc lies about: he says he never killed anyone (he has), and that the culvert grate is easy to open (it takes a DC 15 Strength (Athletics) check, or a DC 13 Dexterity check with thieves' tools to pick the lock that holds it).

The hidden stash

Brannoc keeps the Rook's letters where his own crew can't read them: in a hollow under the roots of the oak that holds the scout's tree stand, covered with a flat stone and leaf litter.

Finding it. Each search of the camp takes 10 minutes and needs a DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) or Intelligence (Investigation) check. These things help:

- **Brannoc's eyes.** If Brannoc is captured, a character who succeeds on a DC 12 Wisdom (Insight) check while he's being questioned notices him glancing at the oak. The next search has Advantage.
- **A captured bandit** knows Brannoc "goes off by the big oak at night", and says so with a DC 10 Charisma (Intimidation) or Charisma (Persuasion) check.
- **Jory's tip.** If the party won the interrogation, they know the papers aren't in the tent.

Taking too long. After the **third failed search**, three Crows returning from a raid (two bandits and a tough) walk into the camp. Once they are dealt with, the party finds the stash without a further check.

What's in the stash (a waxed leather pouch):

- **Letters from the Rook**, signed "**Rook, King of the Ashwood**" with the squat tower seal. They order more raids "until every merchant in my kingdom pays his king", and promise Brannoc a lordship "when I am crowned".
- **A tally of tribute** paid into "the King's treasury" by other gangs, merchants, and farms. The list is long.
- **A map** of the abandoned forest road north to **Ashwatch**, with the lookout's ruined watchtower marked.
- **A slip of paper** with this month's password.

Together, these tell the party what Brannoc would: the Rook wants to be the only boss in the region and sees himself as a king, and his base is Ashwatch, the old fort in the woods.

Brannoc's tent

Brannoc's tent holds his bedroll, fine clothes, and a strongbox (locked; DC 13 Dexterity check with thieves' tools, or break it open with a DC 15 Strength check) with 85 gp, 140 sp, and three gold rings worth 15 gp each. There are no papers.

The stolen goods

The crates and bales under the tarps are worth about 300 gp. Some are Marsh Freight's, taken in earlier raids. Returning them to Harrowgate takes the horses and a wagon from the town. Hester and the other merchants are grateful (see the adventure).

Scaling

- **Weaker party (level 1–2):** Use the Bandit Captain stat block from SRD 5.2 for Brannoc instead (as Sable's, in Act 1), and remove two bandits (600 XP).
- **Stronger party (level 4–5):** Add two toughs and a second scout (1,200 XP).

Stat blocks

Brannoc (Warrior Veteran) (1)

Brannoc uses the SRD 5.2 Warrior Veteran stat block with no changes. He also wears three gold rings and carries the key to his strongbox.

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 17 · **Initiative** +3 (13)
- **HP** 65 (10d8 + 20)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
16 (+3)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)	10 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +3, Dex +1, Con +2, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Skills** Athletics +5, Perception +2
- **Gear** Greatsword, Heavy Crossbow, Splint Armor
- **Senses** Passive Perception 12
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 3 (XP 700; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The warrior makes two Greatsword or Heavy Crossbow attacks.
- ***Greatsword.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 10 (2d6 + 3) Slashing damage.
- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 12 (2d10 + 1) Piercing damage.

Reactions

- ***Parry.*** *Trigger:* The warrior is hit by a melee attack roll while holding a weapon. *Response:* The warrior adds 2 to its AC against that attack, possibly causing it to miss.

Brannoc (Bandit Captain) (weaker party only)

For a party of level 1–2, Brannoc uses the SRD 5.2 Bandit Captain stat block instead. **Change:** his Pistol is replaced with a Hand Crossbow. He surrenders when Bloodied (26 HP or fewer).

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 15 · **Initiative** +3 (13)
- **HP** 52 (8d8 + 16)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	16 (+3)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	11 (+0)	14 (+2)

- **Saving Throws** Str +4, Dex +5, Con +2, Int +2, Wis +2, Cha +2
- **Skills** Athletics +4, Deception +4
- **Gear** Hand Crossbow, Scimitar, Studded Leather Armor
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 2 (XP 450; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** Brannoc makes two attacks, using Scimitar and Hand Crossbow in any combination.
- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +5, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) Slashing damage.
- ***Hand Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +5, range 30/120 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d6 + 3) Piercing damage.

Reactions

- ***Parry.*** *Trigger:* Brannoc is hit by a melee attack roll while holding a weapon. *Response:* Brannoc adds 2 to his AC against that attack, possibly causing it to miss.

Bandit (4, plus 2 returning raiders)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 11 (2d8 + 2)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	12 (+1)	12 (+1)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +1, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Light Crossbow, Scimitar
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common, Thieves' Cant
- **CR** 1/8 (XP 25; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Scimitar.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +3, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 4 (1d6 + 1) Slashing damage.
- ***Light Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 80/320 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d8 + 1) Piercing damage.

Scout (1)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 13 · **Initiative** +2 (12)
- **HP** 16 (3d8 + 3)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
11 (+0)	14 (+2)	12 (+1)	11 (+0)	13 (+1)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +0, Dex +2, Con +1, Int +0, Wis +1, Cha +0
- **Skills** Nature +4, Perception +5, Stealth +6, Survival +5
- **Gear** Leather Armor, Longbow, Shortsword
- **Senses** Passive Perception 15
- **Languages** Common plus one other language
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Actions

- ***Multiattack.*** The scout makes two attacks, using Shortsword and Longbow in any combination.
- ***Shortsword.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Piercing damage.
- ***Longbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +4, range 150/600 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d8 + 2) Piercing damage.

Tough (returning raiders; also for a stronger party)

Medium or Small Humanoid, Neutral

- **AC** 12 · **Initiative** +1 (11)
- **HP** 32 (5d8 + 10)
- **Speed** 30 ft.

Str	Dex	Con	Int	Wis	Cha
15 (+2)	12 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

- **Saving Throws** Str +2, Dex +1, Con +2, Int +0, Wis +0, Cha +0
- **Gear** Heavy Crossbow, Leather Armor, Mace
- **Senses** Passive Perception 10
- **Languages** Common
- **CR** 1/2 (XP 100; PB +2)

Traits

- ***Pack Tactics.*** The tough has Advantage on an attack roll against a creature if at least one of the tough's allies is within 5 feet of the creature and the ally doesn't have the Incapacitated condition.

Actions

- ***Mace.*** *Melee Attack Roll:* +4, reach 5 ft. *Hit:* 5 (1d6 + 2) Bludgeoning damage.

- ***Heavy Crossbow.*** *Ranged Attack Roll:* +3, range 100/400 ft. *Hit:* 6 (1d10 + 1) Piercing damage.

Encounter tracker

Creature	AC	HP	Damage taken	Conditions	Initiative
Brannoc (warrior veteran; weaker party: bandit captain, AC 15, HP 52)	17	65			
Bandit 1	12	11			
Bandit 2	12	11			
Bandit 3 (removed for a weaker party)	12	11			
Bandit 4 (removed for a weaker party)	12	11			
Scout 1 (tree stand)	13	16			
Tough 1 (stronger party only)	12	32			
Tough 2 (stronger party only)	12	32			
Scout 2 (stronger party only)	13	16			
Returning bandit 1 (after the third failed search)	12	11			
Returning bandit 2 (after the third failed search)	12	11			
Returning tough (after the third failed search)	12	32			

The Lookout Post

To be written.

Planned: a hidden lookout watching the road. The party can sneak past it, take it by surprise, or fight. The encounter includes full stat blocks, scaling notes, and an encounter tracker.

Act 3: The Bandit Lord

Session 3. Level 3.

The party reaches Ashwatch, the old toll fort deep in the Ashwood where the Rook, the self-styled King of the Ashwood, holds court over the Crows. They can sneak in, bargain, or fight their way through, and in the end they confront the Rook.

Place in the story

- **Comes from:** Act 2: The Trail.
- **Leads to:** The end of the adventure: the bounty, the road reopening, and hooks back into your campaign.

Adventures

1. The Bandit Lord's Lair

Encounters

1. The Lair Gate
2. The Bandit Lord

The Bandit Lord's Lair

To be written.

Planned: the old toll fort and its map, ways in (sneaking, parley, assault), the Lair Gate, the confrontation with the Bandit Lord, and how the adventure can end.

The Lair Gate

To be written.

Planned: the guards at the fort's gate. The encounter includes full stat blocks, scaling notes, and an encounter tracker.

The Bandit Lord

To be written.

Planned: the confrontation with the Rook and his bodyguards. The Rook gets his own stat block, with parley and surrender options, scaling notes, and an encounter tracker.

Key NPCs

NPCs who matter to the story: allies, villains, quest givers, and anyone the party must meet again.

The Rook

- **Role:** Villain. A greedy warlord who wants to be the only boss in the region and sees himself as a king, the "King of the Ashwood". Leads the Crows from Ashwatch, an old toll fort deep in the Ashwood.
- **Description:** Not seen until Act 3. His toll and his crow-feather tokens (a black feather through a copper ring stamped with a squat tower) are everywhere on the road.
- **Appears in:** Guarding the Caravan, The Bandit Lord

Sable

- **Role:** The Rook's lieutenant. Leads the ambush that kills Tobin Marsh.
- **Description:** Cold and precise. A bandit captain with a hand crossbow. Carries the Crows' toll ledger.
- **Appears in:** Attack 2: The Midway Ambush, Attack 3: Before Harrowgate

Tobin Marsh

- **Role:** Coach driver who hires the party. Killed at Crow's Ford.
- **Description:** Weathered, stubborn, and kind. Hester Marsh's cousin. Refuses to pay the Rook's toll.
- **Appears in:** Guarding the Caravan, Attack 2: The Midway Ambush

Hester Marsh

- **Role:** Head of Marsh Freight in Harrowgate. Pays the party, rewards them for how they treated Tobin's body, and with Captain Vane asks them to investigate the Crows.
- **Description:** Tobin's cousin. Clever, practical, grieving. Wants the road back, not revenge.
- **Appears in:** Following the Trail

Gully

- **Role:** Crow who demands the toll outside Millbrook.
- **Description:** A big, cheerful, not very bright tough.

- **Appears in:** Attack 1: Outside Millbrook

Captain Roderick Vane

- **Role:** Captain of the Harrowgate guard. With Hester, asks the party to investigate the Crows, and makes them deputies.
- **Description:** Sixties, grey-bearded, limps from an old wound. Honest, tired, and blunt.
- **Appears in:** Following the Trail

Morwen Tull

- **Role:** Keeper of the Iron Harrow inn, and a source of rumors.
- **Description:** Talkative and well-informed; keeps the best rooms for guests who tip.
- **Appears in:** Following the Trail

Jory Fennick

- **Role:** Young Crow prisoner in the Harrowgate jail. Tells the party about Brannoc's camp if they win the skill challenge.
- **Description:** Seventeen, skinny, scared. Son of old Fennick the stablemaster.
- **Appears in:** Following the Trail

Brannoc, "the Magpie"

- **Role:** Crow lieutenant who runs the forward camp in the Ashwood. Knows what the Rook wants and where his fort is, if the party keeps him alive.
- **Description:** Forties, lean, neat black beard, fingers full of stolen rings. Vain and greedy; fears the Rook, but talks to save his life.
- **Appears in:** The Crow Camp, Following the Trail

Key locations

Places that matter to the story: cities, dungeons, strongholds, and important sites.

Millbrook

- **Role:** Starting town. Tobin hires the party at the Plough and Lantern tavern.
- **Description:** A river-valley town at the west end of the Old Trade Road. Placeholder name; rename to fit your world.
- **Appears in:** Guarding the Caravan

Harrowgate

- **Role:** Destination of the caravan and home of Marsh Freight and Captain Vane's guard. Where Act 2 begins.
- **Description:** A walled market town at the east end of the Old Trade Road. Placeholder name.
- **Appears in:** Following the Trail, Attack 3: Before Harrowgate

The Old Trade Road

- **Role:** The road the Rook wants to control. Three days' travel through farmland, the Ashwood, and hills.
- **Description:** The only good wagon road between Millbrook and Harrowgate.
- **Appears in:** Guarding the Caravan, Road Encounters

Crow's Ford

- **Role:** Where Sable's ambush kills Tobin Marsh.
- **Description:** A knee-deep, 40-foot-wide river crossing in the middle of the Ashwood.
- **Appears in:** Attack 2: The Midway Ambush

The Iron Harrow

- **Role:** The inn on Harrowgate's market square where the party stays, paid for by Hester. Scene of the morning meeting.
- **Description:** A solid stone inn with an old iron harrow blade bolted above its door. Kept by Morwen Tull.
- **Appears in:** Following the Trail

The Crow camp

- **Role:** Brannoc's forward camp, from which the Crows raid the Harrowgate end of the road.
- **Description:** An old charcoal burners' clearing at the eastern edge of the Ashwood, half a day from Harrowgate along the woodcutters' track.
- **Appears in:** The Crow Camp

Ashwatch

- **Role:** The Rook's base. An old toll fort on an abandoned forest road deep in the Ashwood, a day's march north of the Crow camp. A lookout in a ruined watchtower on the old road guards the approach.
- **Description:** Abandoned fifty years ago when the road was moved. The Rook holds court on a throne in its old toll hall. Its mark, a squat tower, is stamped on every crow-feather token.
- **Appears in:** The Crow Camp, Following the Trail, The Bandit Lord's Lair